Used to for past habits

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to talk about past habits and past states that are no longer true using **used to + base form**, in affirmative, negative and interrogative sentences.

The idea in two lines: *Used to* describes something that happened regularly or was true in the past but is not true now: *People used to travel by camel across the Sahara.* It has one form for all persons and is followed by the base form of the verb.

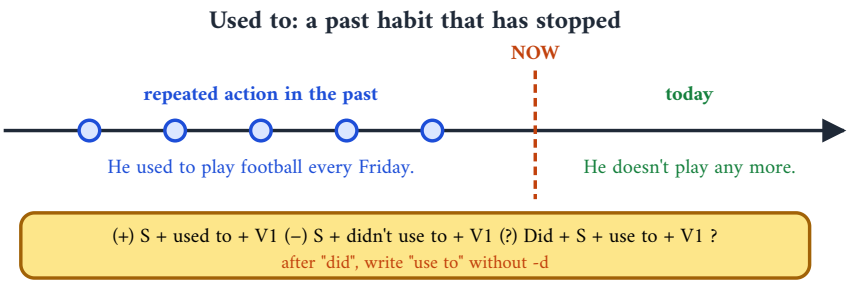


Figure 1: Used to describes a repeated past action or state that is no longer true today.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Affirmative:** *subject + used to + base form. My grandfather used to work in the fields.* The form never changes.
2. **Negative:** *didn't use to + base form* (*use*, no -d). *She didn't use to like history.*
3. **Question:** *Did + subject + use to + base form? Did people use to write with feathers?*
4. **Past habit:** a repeated action that has stopped. *Picasso used to paint every day.*
5. **Past state:** a situation that is no longer true. *This building used to be a palace; now it is a museum.*
6. **Not for a single event:** for one action at a definite time, use the past simple: *He wrote his first poem in 1930.*

7. Contrast words: **but now, nowadays, any more, no longer**. *She used to live in Oran, but now she lives in Annaba.*

🟢 Examples

1. Rewrite with *used to*: *As a child, Charlie Chaplin performed in music halls in London.* **Answer:** As a child, Charlie Chaplin used to perform in music halls in London. **Explanation:** a repeated past activity that stopped.
2. Make the sentence negative: *My parents used to have a television.* **Answer:** My parents didn't use to have a television. **Explanation:** with *didn't*, the -d of *used* disappears.
3. Ask a question: *… your grandmother … (tell) you stories at night?* **Answer:** Did your grandmother use to tell you stories at night? **Explanation:** *Did + subject + use to + base form.*

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Writing "use to" in the affirmative: "He *use to* play". Write *used to*.
- Writing "didn't *used* to" or "Did he *used* to". After *did*, write *use to*.
- A past verb after *used to*: "used to *went*" instead of *used to go*.
- Using *used to* for a present habit: "Nowadays I used to study every evening." Present habits take the present simple.

🟡 Quick review

- used to + base form = past habit or past state, not true now.
- Same form for all subjects: I / he / we used to.
- Negative: didn't use to; question: Did … use to … ?
- Single dated event → past simple, not used to.
- Often with: but now, nowadays, any more, no longer.

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